

Part I – Delaware K–12 Civic Education Landscape (Front 1)

A. Delaware civics standards: scope, grade levels, recency

- Delaware's K–12 social studies framework includes a dedicated civics strand organized around four anchor standards: Government, Politics, Citizenship, and Participation, laid out as a grade-band progression (K–3, 4–5, 6–8, 9–12).
- External scans and DDOE documents indicate these civics standards were last substantively revised in 2018; the "DE K–12 Civics Standards 2018" file remains the operative standards as of 2024–25, with no evidence of a post-2020 civics rewrite. (Pre-2020 but still current.)
- In elementary grades, participation appears in K–3 as "skills necessary for participating in a group" (defining an objective, dividing responsibilities, working cooperatively), and again in grades 4–5 as understanding and employing the formal and informal methods democratic groups use to function.
- In middle school, each civics anchor appears at least once, but the participation anchor is only explicitly highlighted once, focused on following elected officials and understanding mechanisms to communicate with them, limiting repeated practice in participation.
- In high school, civics content is mainly delivered through a 10th-grade "Civics and Economics" course and 11th-grade U.S. History; local course descriptions align to Delaware civics standards on the Constitution, politics, and citizenship/participation, but participation standards are concentrated in grade 9 with little explicit participatory requirement in grades 10–12.

B. DDOE guidance, initiatives, and implementation supports

- The DDOE Social Studies office provides statewide standards, assessments, and professional learning, but leaves curriculum decisions to districts and charters; civics is treated as a core strand within the broader social studies framework.
- The Delaware Social Studies Coalition, working with DDOE, supports districts by developing benchmark-aligned assessments, model lessons, and staff development, which indirectly shape local civics implementation.
- The Delaware Center for Civics Education (DCCE) at the University of Delaware serves as the state coordinator for We the People, aligning resources with Delaware standards, producing model lessons, and supporting civics grant implementation.
- DCCE leads the Delaware Civics Education Coalition, a nonpartisan network committed to elevating civic education as a state priority, conducting environmental scans of civics policies and opportunities, offering professional learning around Delaware civics standards (especially grades 4, 7, 11), and laying groundwork for school and teacher recognition programs in civics.
- The Democracy Project Summer Institute (running over 25 years) is described by DDOE's social studies associate as Delaware's "premier civic education experience" for

K–12 educators, equipping teachers with tools and knowledge to foster civic engagement and democratic classroom practices statewide.

- In 2025 DDOE secured an \$8.7M U.S. Department of Education grant for "Literacy for We the People," partnering with DCCE, the Center for Civic Education, and Georgetown's Civic Education Research Lab to develop a statewide educator toolkit integrating structured literacy with civic and constitutional content plus intensive professional development.
- Delaware participates in the Civics that Empowers All Students (CEAS) initiative: DCCE offers 52 hours of PD for grades 4, 7, and 8 teachers, providing class sets of We the People texts, ongoing support, and training in simulated congressional hearings and inclusive civics pedagogy.

C. Assessments and accountability

- Delaware's DeSSA Social Studies assessments in grades 4, 7, and 11 test civics, economics, geography, and history against state standards, with the aim of producing "competent citizens" who understand democratic principles and structures.
- A 7th-grade scope and sequence shows DDOE-aligned Delaware Recommended Curriculum (DRC) units like "Project Participate," "Civil Rights & Political Freedom," and performance tasks such as "How Government Responds to a Health Crisis," indicating some project-style and performance-based civics assessments but no universal civics capstone.
- National inventories and benchmarking scans place Delaware among states with updated social studies standards and some assessments, but not among those with a dedicated civics graduation exam, mandated civics course, or civics project requirement. (Several of these sources are pre-2020 but remain the most recent comprehensive scans.)

D. Gaps vs C3 Framework and CIRCLE recommendations

1. C3 Framework comparison

- The C3 Framework calls for an "Inquiry Arc" (develop questions, apply disciplinary concepts, evaluate sources, take informed action) and explicitly aims at preparing students for active participation in civic life, not just knowledge acquisition.
- Delaware's civics standards embed some C3-like elements, e.g., analyzing government and politics, participation skills like group work and communicating with officials but external analysis finds that participatory anchors are sporadic and largely absent after 9th grade, with no statewide requirement that all students complete an inquiry-to-action civic project.
- There is no clear evidence that Delaware has formally adopted C3 or revised its standards since 2018 to explicitly integrate the Inquiry Arc or "taking informed action" language, whereas Illinois, Massachusetts, and others have explicitly tied standards and laws to

C3-style inquiry and informed action. (C3 adoption comparisons rely partly on pre-2020 scans and should be treated as indicative, not definitive.)

2. CIRCLE's equitable civic learning benchmarks

- CIRCLE's research on equitable K–12 civic learning emphasizes action civics (student-selected, researched, and undertaken community projects), discussions of current and controversial issues, authentic student voice in institutional decision-making, and explicit attention to structural inequities that shape civic opportunity.
- Illinois and Massachusetts, where CIRCLE is directly involved, have codified these practices: laws and guidance require discussion of current issues, service learning through informed action, simulations of democratic processes, and at least one student-led civics project, with targeted funding and professional development.
- Delaware shows partial alignment through DCCE's Democracy Project and CEAS (inquiry, simulations, hearings) and some DRC performance tasks, but there is no universal civics project requirement, no civics seal, and no statewide framework ensuring that every student experiences high-quality action civics.
- Learning Policy Institute's 2023 review of state support for civic engagement highlights how leading states pair standards and project requirements with dedicated funding, educator PD, capstone models, and seals of civic engagement; Delaware currently lacks this level of systemic infrastructure.

3. Summary of structural gaps (aligned to 4 filters)

- Filter 1 – Statewide coherence and local implementation: Delaware has standards and assessments but no statutory civics course, project mandate, or civics seal, producing greater variance across LEAs than in benchmark states with codified civics requirements and guidance.
- Filter 2 – Real power vs symbolic engagement: Standards and some curricula mention communication with officials and civil discourse, but there is little evidence of systemic, statewide structures pushing students into decision-making roles (e.g., participatory budgeting, sustained campaigns, shared school governance).
- Filter 3 – Hands-on practice tied to real decisions: DRC units and We the People hearings provide authentic experiences for some students; however, Delaware lacks a universal requirement analogous to Massachusetts' and Rhode Island's student-led civics project mandates or Illinois' required service learning through informed action.
- Filter 4 – Strategic nonviolence and leadership: Delaware's public civics standards and DDOE guidance do not foreground nonviolent strategy, organizing capacity, or conflict navigation, though We the People/CEAS and Democracy Project PD include deliberation and inquiry; this remains a large design space for Network Delaware to differentiate its model.

E. Existing programs, pilots, and partnerships in Delaware

- Democracy Project Summer Institute (DCCE/UD): Week-long institute with model lessons and civic engagement strategies, widely treated as the premier civics PD experience in Delaware and endorsed by DDOE's social studies associate.
- Civics that Empowers All Students (CEAS) Delaware: Intensive PD for grades 4, 7, 8 teachers on implementing We the People and simulated congressional hearings, coupled with class materials and stipends; Delaware is part of a national CEAS grant program focused on equitable civic instruction.
- Literacy for We the People: State-led project to create a comprehensive educator toolkit that integrates structured literacy with civic and constitutional content, using PD and research partnerships to scale implementation.
- Delaware Civics Education Coalition: Environmental scan, awareness-raising, PD, and planned recognition programs (e.g., "Centers for Excellence in Civics Education"), indicating a move toward statewide coherence but with deliverables and impacts still emerging.
- District examples (illustrative): New Castle County Vo-Tech's Civics and Economics course, Colonial SD's K–12 curriculum emphasizing democratic roles and translating beliefs into action, and DeSSA-aligned DRC units like "Project Participate" show that some schools are already embedding civic participation, albeit unevenly.

F. Equity considerations for priority communities

1. Immigrant and mixed-status families

- DDOE's immigrant student guidance affirms equal access to K–12 education regardless of immigration status, prohibits discrimination on race, color, national origin, or immigration status, and bars schools from requesting immigration documentation.
- The state commits to disseminating federal guidance, offering PD to districts, and revising enrollment policies, but there is no civics-specific strategy around immigrant rights literacy, sanctuary policies, or safe pathways for immigrant youth civic participation.

2. Multilingual learners and multilingual families

- Multilingual learners now comprise around 13% of Delaware's student population (~19,000 students, over 100 home languages), making them the fastest-growing group.
- WHYY's 2025 report finds Delaware provides about \$1,100 per multilingual learner in opportunity funding, compared with \$6,000–\$9,000 in New Jersey and Maryland, and describes the funding formula as "frozen in time," with reforms under discussion.
- DDOE indicates that new literacy initiatives are being designed with multilingual learners "from the forefront," but there is no clear evidence of civics-specific investments

(e.g., bilingual civics materials, parent civic leadership programs) targeted to MLL-dense schools.

3. Black and Brown youth; Hispanic and Latino communities

- SB 297 (2024) mandates that the history of racial, ethnic, and cultural groups, including, originally, Asian American, Native Hawaiian, and Pacific Islander communities but ultimately all groups will be integrated into K–12 curricula; advocates framed it as a response to rising racist harassment and a mechanism to ensure students can "see themselves" in their textbooks.
- Implementation will require DOE to draft new standards; the process is ongoing and may be lengthy, but it opens space to link inclusive history with civics content on movements, resistance, and structural inequality, consistent with "truth-telling without blame." (Implementation status is actively evolving and should be monitored.)
- Caution should be taken, or proactive measures to counter civic education opponents who will frame this knowledge increase as some sort of anti-white narrative

4. Disabled students and families

- No Delaware civics or social studies documents reviewed explicitly integrate disability history or disability-inclusive civic participation expectations (e.g., multiple participation formats, leadership roles for disabled students), beyond general non-discrimination.
- National guidance on experiential civic learning and inclusive civic education stresses universal design, multiple participation pathways, and integration of disability rights and history; this is a clear design gap and opportunity relative to Network Delaware's accessibility principle.

5. LGBTQIA+ youth

- DDOE civics/social studies resources do not presently foreground LGBTQIA+ history, civic issues, or safety in public-facing civic actions, despite broader legal protections against discrimination on sexual orientation and gender identity in education.
- Research on inclusive civic education recommends attention to democratic school climate, non-disclosure-optional leadership roles, and explicit teaching about anti-discrimination frameworks; Delaware's civics landscape leaves these largely to local discretion.